It also bears reiteration that, throughout this book's analyses of architectural groups, prior scholarship has been invaluable as a starting point. Similarly here, the Italian, French, and other surveys and excavations at Ghazna and Bust-Laskhari Bazar obviate the need for exhaustive descriptions; they provide the solid bases for tracing the transformations of Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar into "new" imperial spaces.

Eastern Impulses

The long "house arrest" inflicted on the sons of Baha' al-Din by the infamous 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz*, their paternal uncle, ended only after the latter's death: perhaps helping to heal the familial breach, 'Ala' al-Din's son and successor Saif al-Din freed his cousins, even inviting the elder Shams al-Din into his retinue, while Shihab al-Din went to yet another paternal uncle, Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud, the patriarch of the Bamiyan lineage.[3] Fatefully, Shams al-Din participated in the campaign against the Oghüz in Gharjistan in AH 558/1163 CE, when Saif al-Din met his tragic death at the hands of the treacherous 'Abbas ibn Shish. It was this unforeseen event that led to Shams al-Din's crowning as Sultan Ghiyath al-Din at Firuzkuh in the same year (cf. Chapter 1).

Shihab al-Din's trajectory toward rulership was more protracted and uncertain. Juzjani implied to his readers that a stinging rebuke by Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud of his nephew's complacency finally stirred the young man's ambition. Upon sensing Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud's deep displeasure, Shihab al-Din apparently left Bamiyan for his newly crowned brother's court at Firuzkuh, where he surely had hopes of attaining independence and even distinction. When these hopes were not immediately fulfilled, Shihab al-Din withdrew to Sistan, taking refuge for about a year in Zaranj at the court of Malik Shams al-Din Nasri (r. AH 559–564/1164–1169 CE) – apparently a cruel tyrant to his own people, but eager to preserve good relations with his overlords the Firuzkuh Shansabanis.[4] Sultan Ghiyath al-Din coaxed his younger brother back to Ghur and bestowed on him the Istiya area, which lay in the vicinity of Tiginabad/Old Qandahar (cf. Chapter 3): it had been the appanage of the late patriarch Saif al-Din Suri (d. AH 543/1149 CE) during the early days of the Shansabanis' regional dominance. Eventually, Shihab al-Din was given the bigger prize of Tiginabad/Old Qandahar itself. But this territory came with challenges due to its proximity to the Oghüz encampments in Ghazna and its environs.

With historical hindsight, it becomes clear that avuncular rebuke *alone* was not responsible for Shihab al-Din broadening his horizons, just as appeasing sibling tensions in itself was insufficient for Sultan Ghiyath al-Din to mobilize Firuzkuh's forces toward the conquest of Ghazna. In addition to these intimate impetuses, a sequence of specific events had to